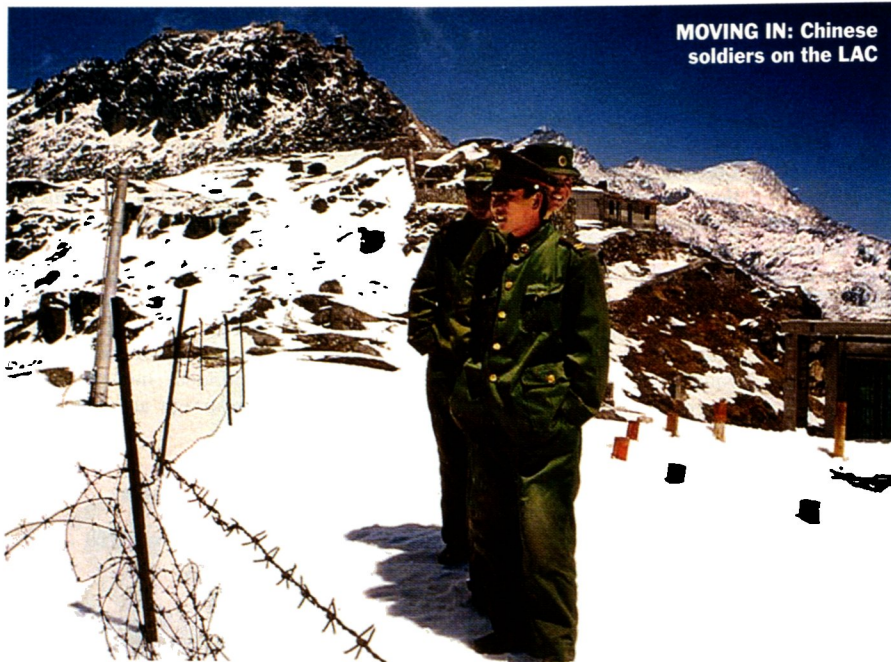


As India and China inch forward on boundary negotiations, there are worrying intelligence reports that the Chinese are covertly making intrusions into Indian territory to bolster their claims

CREEPING AGG

■ By Saurabh Shukla

For close to 60 years now India and China have viewed each other with suspicion. In the past decade though, there has been a marked thaw with both sides deciding not to allow the vexatious border issue to hold up their relationship and to allow trade to grow. That policy proved successful as the bilateral trade crossed \$20 billion (Rs 78,660 crore) early this year. There was even promise that the border issue was heading towards a peaceful resolution with the two sides setting up a high-level mechanism to intensify talks. Only last week, National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan wrapped up another round of boundary talks with

his Chinese counterpart Dai Bingguo with both sides reporting progress.

So on surface everything looks normal and placid. But it is little known that dark clouds of mistrust are gathering again as India's intelligence agencies report a worrying rise in Chinese intrusions with many of them deep enough to cause alarm. A confidential report INDIA TODAY has access to, suggests that as many as 130 incursions by the Chinese forces have been reported on the Sino-Indian boundary in 2007, taking the number to over 300 intrusions in just two years. Even more serious is the input that there is a growing concentration of over 10,000 Chinese soldiers across the border in Tawang sector in Arunachal Pradesh, indicating that a full division of the People's

Liberation Army (PLA) of China has been brought in the area. Considering that China has refused to recognise Arunachal Pradesh as part of India—describing it as a disputed territory—and has been laying claim to the state, such a build-up is a cause for concern.

Last month, on September 13, intelligence agencies had reported six intrusions on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) by the Chinese with some of their patrols coming as deep as 5.5 km inside the Indian territory in Jammu and Kashmir sector. "If there indeed are incursions by the Chinese then the Defence Ministry has some serious explanation to do on when and where this is happening and for how long," says Major-General (retired) Himmat Singh Gill, who commandeered a